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Rules Handoff Guide

Use this guide when you need to describe **constraints, validations, classifications, derivations, equivalences, and state transitions**.

This guide is about **what must be true**, **what is allowed**, and **how values or states are determined**.

KNOWLEDGE AREA

This guide helps with **business rules and decision criteria**. Technically, it covers **business constraints and decision logic**.

Guide family map

Where this guide sits in the full Blueprint Handoff Atlas family.

ROOT & CROSS-CUTTING

Handoff Atlas | Blueprint Bundle | Metamodel Vocabulary | Migrations

DESIGN

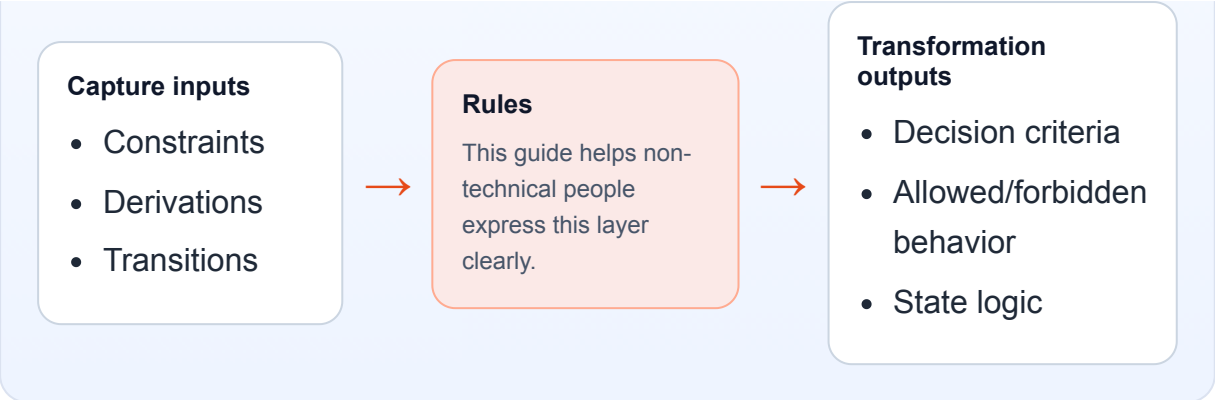
Architecture | Concepts | Domain | Dynamics | Infrastructure | Interactions | Models | Quality | **Rules** | Story

GOVERNANCE

Capability | Decisions | Motivation | Organization | Roadmap | Leverage | Test Cases | Value Stream

Capture → focus → transformation

What to gather first, what this layer focuses on, and what a modeler or AI agent can produce from it.



Main entities in this guide

- **Structural** rule - something that must always be true in the domain.
- **Classification** rule - logic that decides which category something belongs to.
- **Derivation** rule - logic that calculates or derives a value.
- **Equivalence** rule - logic that says when two values or cases count as the same thing.
- **Validation** rule - a check at a system boundary before information is accepted.
- **Transition** - a state-change rule that controls how a concept can move from one state to another.
    - Often confused with: a story or process step. A **Transition** changes lifecycle state; a story step describes what happens in a journey.

What belongs here

- invariants that must always hold
- validation requirements at boundaries
- rules that classify something
- rules that derive a value
- transition rules between states

What does not belong here

- a whole story flow
- raw concept definitions without a rule
- generic design preferences disguised as mandatory business rules

Core things to capture

- the rule statement
- when it applies

- what it requires or forbids
- which concepts or states it affects
- what happens if it is violated

Core relationships to capture

- rule -> concept affected
- rule -> state transition controlled
- rule -> operation or screen where it matters
- rule -> business consequence if broken

Modus operandi

Write rules as explicit business statements:

1. name the rule
2. describe when it applies
3. describe what must or must not happen
4. identify concepts, states, and outcomes affected
5. separate rule meaning from implementation technique

Prompt set

- what must always be true?
- what is forbidden?
- what decides the category or status?
- how is a value derived?
- what conditions allow a state change?

Free-text intake template

- **Rule name:**
- **Type (constraint/validation/classification/derivation/transition):**
- **When it applies:**
- **What it requires or forbids:**
- **Affected concepts/states:**
- **Business consequence if broken:**

Worked example

- A return request may not be approved if the item is outside the allowed return window
- A high-value return request must be classified separately when manual fraud review is required
- A submitted return request may transition to approved, rejected, or completed

Layer-specific handoff guidance

For rules, the handoff should make **obligation and consequence** unambiguous.

The receiver should be able to answer:

- when the rule applies
- what it requires or forbids
- what concept or state it affects
- what happens when it is violated

If a reader could treat the rule as a suggestion instead of a rule, the handoff needs sharpening.

How this becomes YAML

A technical modeler or AI agent can transform this into structural, validation, classification, derivation, equivalence, or transition rule entries linked to concepts and operations.

Common mistakes

- describing a habit or preference as if it were a rule
- forgetting when the rule applies
- mixing process narrative with rule definition
- omitting the affected concept or state